

SUNGYOUN CHUNG

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University of Colorado Boulder
Department of Economics
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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Economics, University of Colorado Boulder	<i>expected May 2027</i>
<i>Advisor: Tania Barham</i>	
M.A., Economics, University of Colorado Boulder	2024
M.A., Economics, Dongguk University, Seoul, South Korea	2022
B.A., Economics, Dongguk University, Seoul, South Korea	2020

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary: Health Economics, Public Economics, Household Finance, Economics of Aging
Secondary: Labor Economics, Applied Microeconomics

JOB MARKET PAPER

Losing the Household CFO: Spousal Exit and Late-Life Wealth

Within couples, one spouse typically manages the household's wealth and finances. This paper estimates what it costs older households when that spouse, the household's CFO, exits and the survivor is forced to take over. Using the Health and Retirement Study's financial-respondent designation and 2,422 spousal deaths, along with 1,635 long-term nursing-home entries and functional incapacitations (4,057 first spousal exits in total), I estimate a difference-in-differences design that compares households that lose their CFO spouse with households that lose the non-CFO spouse to the same events. A stacked triple-difference design that exploits the timing of exits corroborates the estimates. When the CFO spouse dies, the surviving household's net worth falls by \$70,994 on average over the following six years relative to comparison households (\$76,715 across all spousal exits), a loss of about 12 percent of baseline net worth (roughly 17 percent in log terms) and more than the average decline comparison households experience after the same event. The financial-wealth loss sits mainly in stocks, bonds, and individual retirement accounts, is largest when the departed CFO was cognitively normal, and is partly recovered only when a cognitively normal survivor takes over. The evidence points to neglect, accounts left untended after an unplanned succession, rather than liquidation or transfers.

WORKING PAPERS

When Simpler Taxes Meet Aging Minds: Cognitive Decline and Portfolio Reallocation after a State Income Tax Reform

Third Year Paper Award, Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder (2024–2025)

Older Americans hold most of the nation's equity wealth, yet many face cognitive decline that may impair their response to changing financial incentives. I study North Carolina's 2014 income tax reform, which replaced a three-bracket progressive schedule with a flat 5.8% rate, lowering and simplifying the tax on investment income. Using a balanced panel from the Health and Retirement Study and a difference-in-differences design with inverse probability weights, I find that the reform raised stock market participation by 3.0 percentage points and equity holdings by roughly 35%, while safe asset and IRA balances fell by about a quarter. A triple-difference design shows that the response is concentrated among cognitively intact respondents. Those whose word recall declined by 20% or more before the reform did not reallocate on any margin. Because the reform simplified rather than

complicated the tax schedule, the results indicate that the capacity to recognize and act on a changed environment, not tax complexity, constrains older households' portfolio adjustment.

PUBLICATIONS

Does Lawyers' Ability Enhance Litigation Success? Evidence from Korean Tax Appeal Cases

with Inyeob Ji

Korean Journal of Law and Economics, 18(3): 209–230, 2021 (in Korean)

The present article investigates determinants of litigation outcomes. To this end, it examines Korean Supreme Court decisions from which logit regression models are formed and estimated. Its findings suggest that legal representation by large law firms and litigation attorneys (as opposed to advisory attorneys) contribute to litigation success for plaintiff taxpayers. Also, it appears that plaintiff taxpayers have a higher probability of a favorable judgment in national tax cases as opposed to regional tax cases.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

The Long Reach of the ACA Dependent Mandate: Older Parents' Insurance, Labor Supply, and Wealth

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant, University of Colorado Boulder Summer 2025, Summer 2026

Department of Economics, Reporting to Prof. Tania Barham

Randomized evaluation of the ReHire Colorado transitional jobs program for the Colorado Department of Human Services, using linked state administrative data (LINC)

Research Assistant, Dongguk University, Seoul 2020–2021

Projects for the Federation of Korean Industries, the Korean Econometric Society, the Korea Information Society Development Institute, and the Korean Association of Public Finance

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record *University of Colorado Boulder*

- Introduction to Statistics with Computer Applications (ECON 3818): Spring 2026, Summer 2026
- Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 2020): Fall 2025

Teaching Assistant *University of Colorado Boulder*

- Principles of Microeconomics (ECON 2010): Fall 2022, Fall 2024
- Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 2020): Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2025, Summer 2025, Fall 2026
- Intermediate Microeconomic Theory (ECON 3070): Spring 2024

Course Materials Development *University of Colorado Boulder*

- ECON 3070: complete lecture notes, for Prof. Tania Barham (Summer 2024)
- ECON 3818: lecture notes, slides, R practice files and projects (Spring, Summer 2026)
- ECON 2020: lecture slides (Fall 2025); recitation handouts, worksheets, and solutions

Teaching Assistant *Dongguk University, Seoul*

- Principles of Microeconomics; Principles of Macroeconomics: 2020–2021

- Law and Economics: 2021–2022

SCHOLARSHIPS, AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

Third Year Paper Award <i>Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder</i>	2024–2025
Reuben A. Zubrow Fellowship in Economics <i>Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder</i>	2022–2023
Kwon Ohcheol Scholarship (full graduate scholarship) <i>Department of Economics, Dongguk University</i>	2020–2021
Teaching Assistant Scholarship <i>Dongguk University</i>	2020–2021

PRESENTATIONS

<i>University of Colorado Boulder Graduate Student Seminar</i>	2026
<i>University of Colorado Boulder Applied Microeconomics Seminar</i>	2025
<i>Korea's Allied Economic Associations Annual Meeting, Korean Economic Association</i>	2022

SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, L^AT_EX
 Languages: Korean (native), English (fluent), Japanese (intermediate, JLPT N3)

REFERENCES

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